Mazen's Notebook

The Leopard Who Never Showed Up

The guest never arrived!



One week. A brilliant plan. An empty chair.

Sunday: This Is Not a Diary

I am Mazen. I am fourteen. This is an emergency notebook, NOT a diary. Diaries are for people with spare time. This notebook began when our teacher said, "You have one week."



We had to create a school exhibit about the Arabian leopard. I imagined a nice poster, a short speech, then a peaceful return to normal life. I wrote: VERY EASY PLAN.

Later note: never ask that question.

I now know that writing "very easy" at the top of a plan is an excellent way to invite trouble. On Sunday, I was still learning.

One Finger. One Huge Mistake.

"Visitors should leave understanding something," our teacher said. "Not just photograph a poster and forget it." I raised one finger to ask whether this affected our grades. "Excellent, Mazen. You can lead."

Badr raised BOTH hands. I thought he was keen to research. He wanted to know if we could use a loudspeaker. My assistant preferred sound effects to information.



I was only asking!

Team leader: a job I accepted by accident.

We agreed that I would write and he would draw. Ten minutes later, Badr was Head of Ideas. I was in charge of everything that might fall over.

A Literally Enormous Plan

Badr arrived with a cardboard leopard taller than either of us. Size would attract attention, he said. He was right. Everyone trying to use the classroom door noticed us.

We turned it right. Then left. Its tail hit the door. I suggested making it smaller. Badr said I lacked ambition. I suggested a larger door. The caretaker did not laugh.



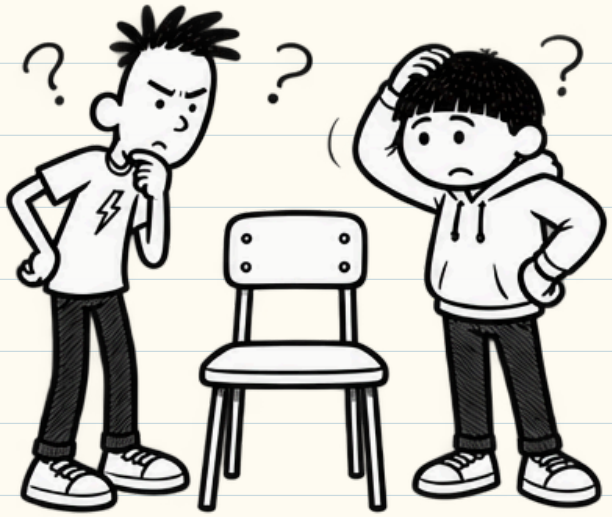
Badr's official proposal.
Rejected.

We cut it down. The leopard finally fitted through the door, but left no room for the exhibit. We had a very large picture and a very small idea.

A Guest without a Seat?

I placed an empty chair in front of the cardboard mountain. "This is the leopard's place," I said. "When is it arriving?" asked Badr. We stared at each other. Then at the chair.

I meant to use its absence to make people curious. Badr thought we were arranging a visit. A wild animal did not need a school invitation. It needed us to care about its world.



No invitation. No arriving guest.

The chair is an idea, not an appointment.

The idea sounded better as I explained it. One awkward question remained: how could an empty chair say all that without me standing beside it and talking forever?

An Expedition Cancelled on Paper

Badr drew himself wearing an explorer's hat and carrying a huge net. He called it "Finding Our Guest". I underlined the word DRAWING before enthusiasm became an actual plan.



We would not search for a wild leopard or approach an animal to prove we cared. We could learn from reliable images and build something for visitors. Fieldwork belonged with specialists.

It is a DRAWING, Badr!

Badr's imaginary expedition. We never went.

Badr said the net was only artistic. I believed him after he crossed "Ask Mum for a tent" off his list. Our first successful expedition was the one we cancelled.

A Leopard... or Is It?

Badr sent a picture to print. I compared it with my reference book. "That is a tiger." "Same family," he said. "My uncle is in my family. I still cannot use his face on my ID."



We compared stripes on the tiger with the Arabian leopard's small, irregular rosettes. Even a simple drawing needed the difference. Otherwise our visitor would learn the wrong thing.

Wrong exhibit, tiger.

Small rosettes, not stripes.

We redrew the cards. Badr kept the tiger in his notebook and labelled it: GUEST AT THE WRONG EXHIBIT. For once, his caption was more accurate than his first drawing.

Research Has No Soundtrack

I opened reliable scientific sources and made short notes, with a source and date beside each fact. Badr suggested epic research music. I explained that laptops do not read faster when they feel heroic.

We learnt that protecting the Arabian leopard involved its habitat and wild prey, and that it faced a serious threat. Our question had to be bigger than how to make it look impressive.



Turn the hero music down.

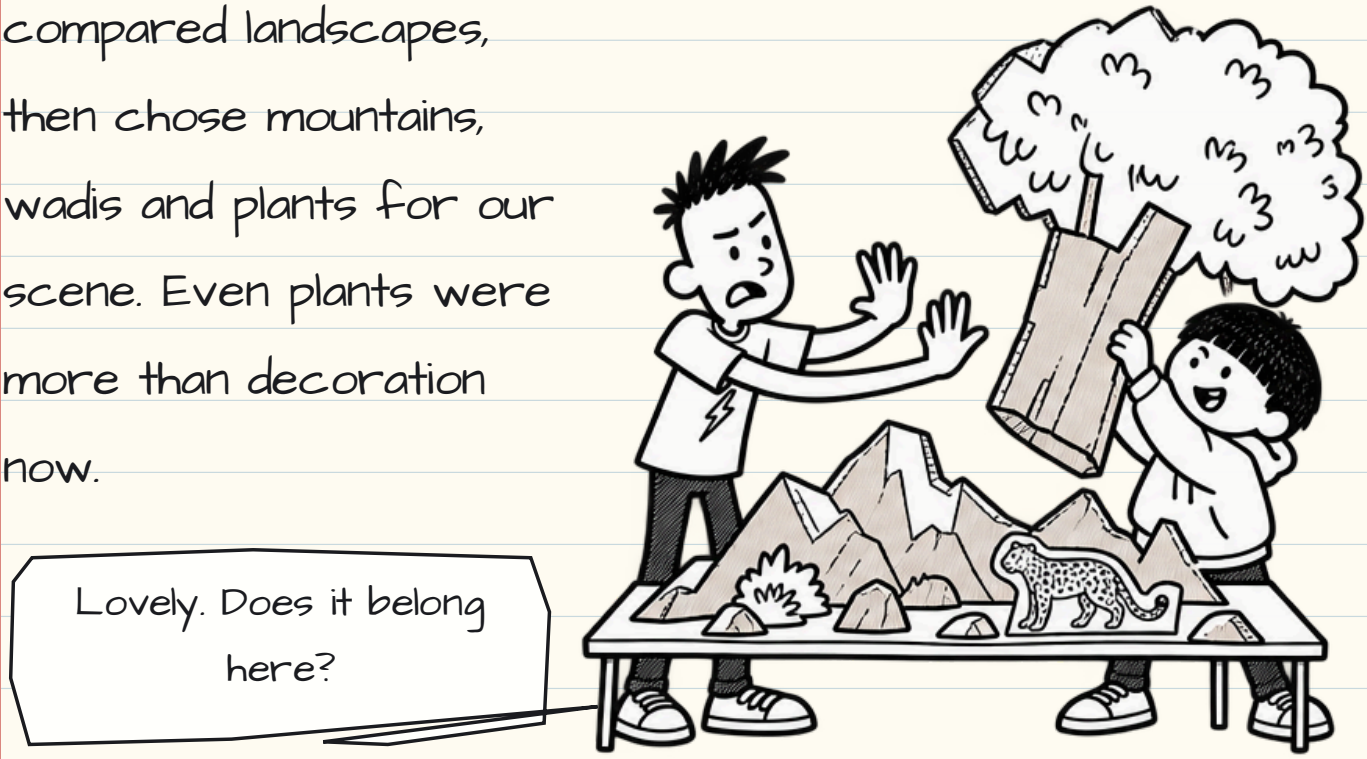
Fact + source + date.

I wrote: WHAT DOES ITS WORLD NEED TO KEEP GOING? Badr studied our cardboard leopard. "We need more than tape, then." At last, we agreed.

A Cardboard Jungle?

Badr brought a cardboard tree that nearly touched the ceiling. I reminded him that we had chosen a rocky mountain reference. We needed to understand the place before filling it with things we liked.

Leopard habitats were not all identical. We compared landscapes, then chose mountains, wadis and plants for our scene. Even plants were more than decoration now.



Not every green thing belongs everywhere.

Badr kept his enormous tree behind our table. It might suit another project, he said. I did not ask about that project. We already had enough problems.

Connected. Mostly by String.

We made plant, ibex and leopard cards, with string for a simple food-relationship example. Badr held one end; I held the other. Within a minute, the string explained our relationship with the table legs.

We untangled it. Plants support herbivores, and a herbivore may be prey for a leopard. Nature is much bigger than three cards. This was a starting point, not a complete map.



Am I in the food chain now?

A simple model. The knot is not included.

What might happen to other animals if part of their habitat changed? Badr lifted his trapped foot. "I think I understand CONNECTED now."

No Spotlight Required

Badr aimed a lamp into our cardboard cave. Visitors needed to see everything, he said. I put the paper leopard inside. Its cave became brighter than the head teacher's office.



We were explaining habitat, space and cover, while building a stage. We tilted the lamp towards the information cards instead. The hiding place stayed part of our idea.

A hiding place is not a studio.

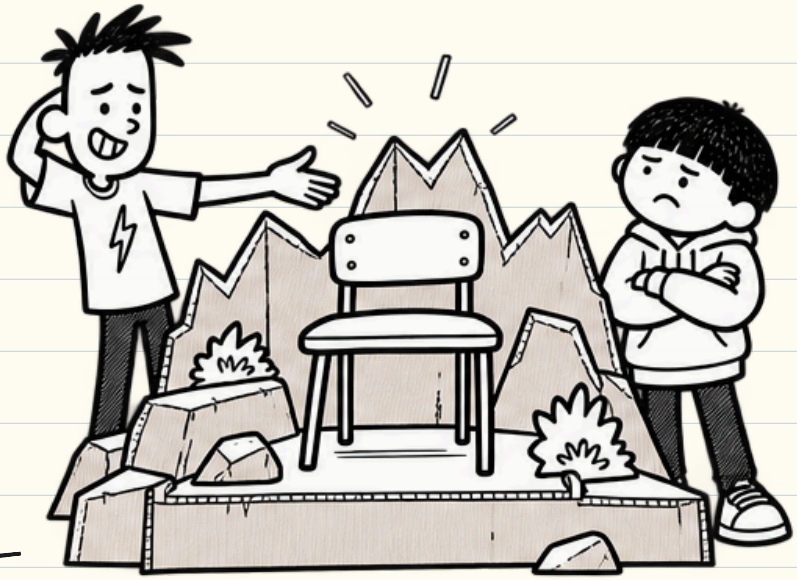
Light the cards. Leave wildlife in peace.

I wrote: caring about an animal does not mean demanding that it appear whenever we want. Badr called our new lighting "ideal for a celebrity who refuses interviews".

Our First Visitor. Our First Silence.

We invited a classmate to try our exhibit. He stared at the empty chair, waited, then asked, "Have you actually started?" I felt the chair staring at me too.

I explained everything at once: habitat, prey, rosettes, the lamp. He nodded and asked where to put his bag. He thought the chair was for him.



Successful test: we found the plan did not work.

After he left, I wrote: THE VISITOR IS NOT THE PROBLEM. We knew the story in our heads. Our exhibit did not tell it yet. Visitors needed something to do, not a speech.

A Mountain Disaster Indoors

I decided to fix the mountain quickly. Badr decided to add another peak. The idea needed height, he said. Two seconds later, the height vanished. So did Badr, behind it.

Nobody was hurt, except our team's dignity. We gathered the paper and returned the lamp to the table. The empty chair was the only part of our exhibit still standing.



Did we really need the height?

Weather report: scattered paper mountains.

Two days remained. "Maybe we should just make a normal poster," I said. For once, Badr did not suggest something bigger. He sat beside me and quietly began peeling off tape.

A Page for Complaints

I listed three complaints: too little time, a weak mountain, and my dislike of public speaking. Writing was supposed to help. All I discovered was that my handwriting improved under stress.

Badr read the list. "Try writing what we can fix." Complaints became questions: What can we remove? How can we steady the mountain? How can visitors join in, so I am not explaining everything?



Many complaints. Solutions pending.

Useful conversion: complaint → question → action.

Suddenly we had specific jobs. My speaking skills had not magically improved. But instead of one enormous disaster, I could see three smaller problems.

The Version That Stays Upright

We built a smaller mountain on a steady base. We reused paper, testing each part before fixing it down. Badr found downsizing personally insulting, but admitted it was nice to see over our landscape.



Visitors could consider three choices: remove cover, reduce wild prey, or protect habitat. Each revealed a question about its effects. No magic points. No pretending nature was simple.

Small. Still standing!

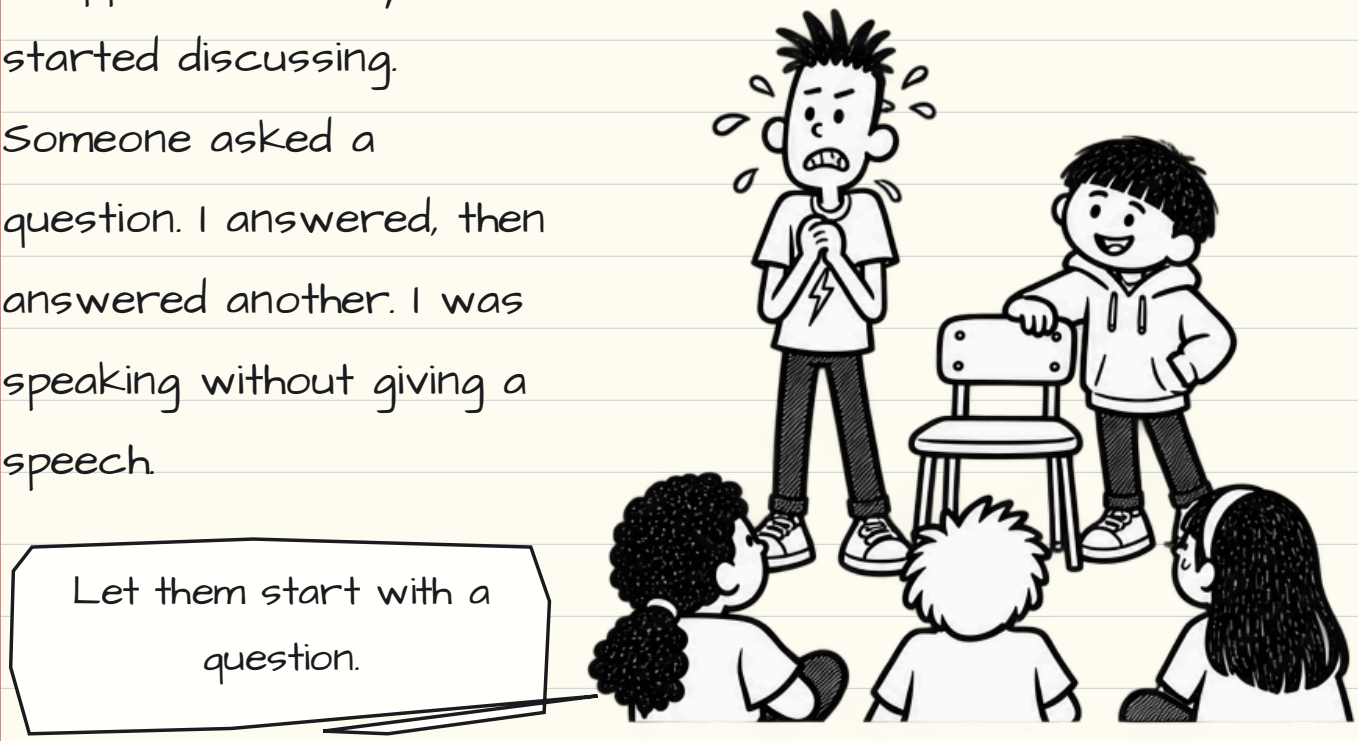
Biggest change: the visitor now takes part.

The chair finally began an activity: its owner was not here, but human choices could affect its world. At last, the chair had an actual job.

Practising Not to Freeze

Three classmates arrived for our second trial. I knew my opening sentence until they looked at me. I made a sound that might have become a word, if it had received more support.

Badr lifted a card. "What might happen if this part disappeared?" They started discussing. Someone asked a question. I answered, then answered another. I was speaking without giving a speech.



Knees: operational, with minor wobbling.

I was more afraid of standing alone than of explaining. A conversation felt easier. A little nervousness remained, mostly to remind me I had knees.

A Question We Had Not Written

A classmate asked: "If we love leopards, why not keep one in the school garden?" Badr had an answer about extra school fees. We decided not to use it.

We explained that caring for wildlife did not mean owning it or bringing it to us. Conservation included habitat, other living things and specialist work. We could learn, spread awareness and respect nature.



Protect its world. Do not bring it here.

A good question deserves a clear answer.

The question went into our notebook. We checked our answer with the teacher. Our exhibit seemed to improve whenever someone asked something we had not expected.

Opening Day. Add Water.

We arrived early. Mountain steady. Cards arranged. Chair correctly empty. Our first visitor carried water. I think the cup saw our exhibit and decided to participate.



I reached for the cup while Badr rescued the cards. Most survived. The HABITAT card acquired an interesting ripple. We dried it and moved drinks to another table.

Open for business. Slightly damp.

Final adjustment: drinks go OVER THERE.

We laughed instead of giving up. It was not a scientific experiment, but it taught us something about plans: allow room for surprises, and a very distant place for water cups.

The Chair That Started Conversations

A younger pupil asked, "Where is the leopard?" "That is where our exhibit begins," I replied. She chose a card and called her friend to discuss it. Soon our empty chair had the busiest crowd.



Visitors considered changes to habitat. We explained that our cards were a simple example. Some changed their minds. Others returned to ask about the difference between leopards and tigers.

No leopard. Plenty of questions.

Live animals at our exhibit: zero.

Success no longer meant "Nice drawing!" It meant a better question, an accurate fact and a useful action. Even Badr stopped asking for a loudspeaker.

After the Applause

Our teacher praised our work, then asked, "What happens after today?" I hoped the answer was a very long sleep. Instead, we agreed to keep a small classroom corner: one checked fact and one new question each week.

We made takeaway cards: learn before sharing, respect wildlife, keep nature clean. Other classmates helped check them. This was no longer just a two-person assignment.

Assignment finished.
Interest ongoing.



A small repeated action beats one day of excitement.

I asked a younger pupil what he would tell his family. "Protecting a leopard includes lots of things around it." I looked at Badr. This time, neither of us needed a joke.

Friday: One Final Note

I returned the chair to class. No leopard had arrived. We had not saved the world in a week. But we had learnt to care more thoughtfully, and helped others care too. Much more than my VERY EASY PLAN.

I opened this notebook
to write the ending.
Badr appeared at the
window with a giraffe
drawing. "Next exhibition."
I closed the book slowly,
opened a fresh page,
and wrote one question.

Before enthusiasm... a tape measure.



The story ends. The notebook stays open.

Did you measure the door this time?

How do you get people to care about a leopard they cannot see?

Mazen wants a quiet school project. Badr wants a brilliant idea. An oversized leopard, a collapsing cardboard mountain and an empty chair turn their week into a glorious mess.

A funny notebook story about friendship, failed plans and a small idea that makes room for wildlife.

Open the notebook. Watch out for the water.

